conducting counterinsurgency operations. Though I have a hard-as-nails exterior, I have a soft core too. This incident made good copy and the media went to town; it even got editorial comments, and led to a debate.

Another reason for the tears in my eyes that morning was the sinking in of my achievement and the recognition accorded by the nation. I had finally emerged victorious in the race for the top slot against three contenders who peeled out one by one, but not before playing out their parts as best as they could. I don't blame them for it, but I was the one whom destiny favoured. It was a subterranean fight. Finally one of the contestants had the grace to say to me, 'Congratulations, JJ.' I gratefully acknowledged his felicitations. Then he said, 'The King is Dead, Long Live the King!' As far as I am concerned, the final lap was the toughest.

'Are the emotive moments orchestrated? Is JJ just trying to repair the army's image, dented as it is with reports of fake kills and human rights violations?' wrote the *Tehelka* of 26 February 2005. These were some of the issues being raised by segments of our media. Continuing, the report in *Tehelka* went on to say, 'It is difficult to find an officer who has a problem with the first Sikh chief's style or manner. Ask former army chief General S. Padmanabhan what he made of a teary JJ and he says, "He has always been a man straight from the heart. It is not a sign of weakness to show emotion."' It further quoted General V.P. Malik, another former chief, as saying, '"JJ has a humane and yet a tough approach. He ensured that Kashmiris were neither alienated nor exposed to any hardship."'[1] [This remark was related to operations in J&K when I was a brigade commander and he (General Malik) happened to be my GOC.] The reaction of the people to this 'humane face' of a military leader was heart-warming. A minister from J&K, Muzaffar Hussain Baig, wrote a letter which, along with some media reports of that period, are reproduced as Appendices 2 and 3 respectively.

Being appointed the chief of army staff of the Indian Army, the second-largest standing army in the world, has definitely been, and most probably shall remain, the most significant event in my life. It